The HERSTORY of Drag in the United States: A Museum Exhibit

By Corey Clancy

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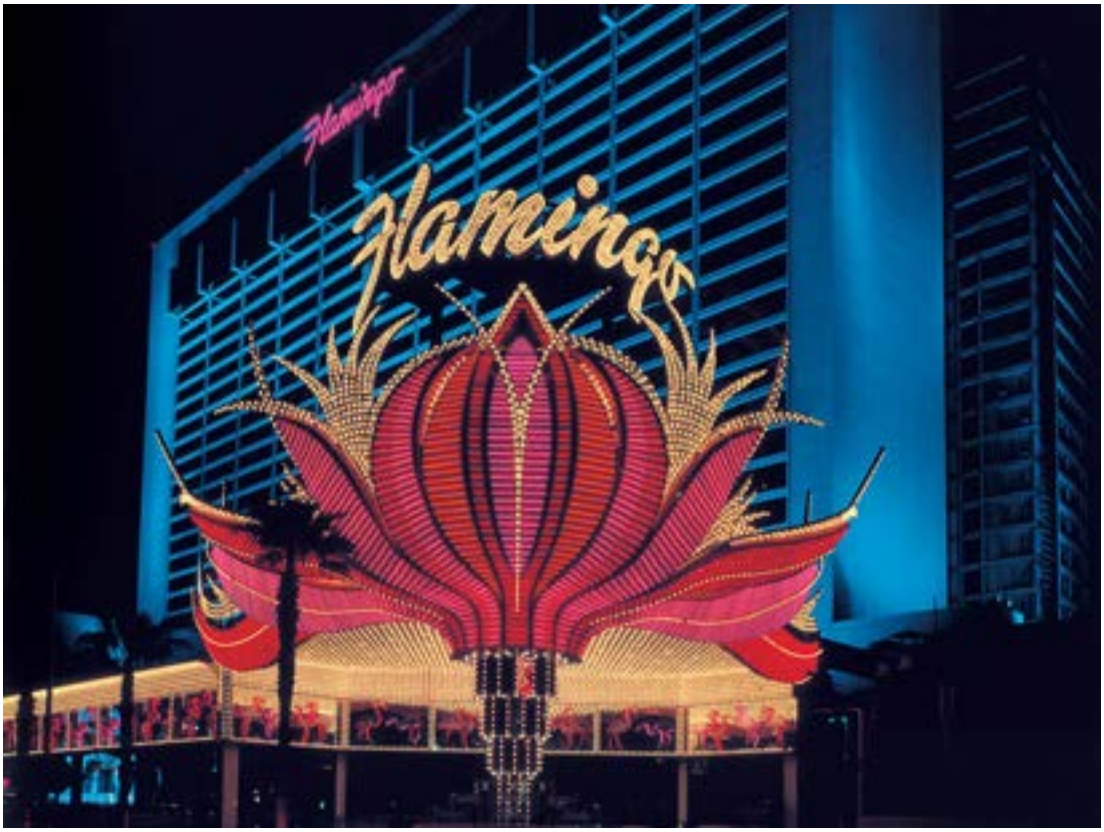
Executive Summary

Located right by "RuPaul's Drag Race Live!" at the Flamingo, Las Vegas is the new "HERstory of Drag Queens in the United States" museum exhibit! Taking visitors on a journey throughout time to show them just how the drag art form has come to be today, this experience will dazzle and inform audiences. Roughly costing about $4,804,610.29 but profiting about $1,591,389.71, the "Herstory of Drag Queens in the United States" exhibit is going to do wonders, donating much of its proceeds to foundations supporting the LGBTQIA+ community. Visitors will face historical moments in times like those characterized by Shakespearean theatre, the Pansy Craze, gay riots, the ballroom scene, RuPaul, and more! The museum exhibit will operate five days a week on the days that the show is being performed, Monday and Thursday through Sunday. It will require fifty employees and be open from 1pm to 1am. With an established fan base and a market longing to learn more about their history, this is the opportunity to be seized upon!

Introduction

In society today, there is much tension between drag queens and drag fans all around the world. Many older queens argue that the new queens today do not know the true history of drag and are only doing it because they were inspired by the show *RuPaul's Drag Race*. On the flip side, newer drag queens argue that it should not make a difference how they found drag, but rather it should just be celebrated that this art form helps them find themselves and brings a community together. To combat this problem, a new fifteen-minute walkthrough museum exhibit titled "The HERstory of Drag Queens in the United States" will be added to the Flamingo, Las Vegas where the current show "RuPaul's Drag Race Live!" is being performed!

Flamingo, Las Vegas



https://www.visitlasvegas.com/listing/flamingo-las-vegas/34510/

RuPaul's Drag Race Live



https://tasteofreality.com/rpdr-vegas-revue-naomi-yvie-vanjie/

The Big Idea and the Story

To achieve the goal of telling the story of the HERstory (history) of drag within the United States, the museum exhibit will be separated into six different rooms characterized by critical moments in drag HERstory. In order of which room a guest encounters first, the rooms are "The Birth of Drag," "The Pansy Craze," "The War on Drag," "The Ballroom," "The Reign of RuPaul," and "The Future of Drag." As a guest progresses through these rooms, they will be fully immersed within the culture of drag throughout different periods of its HERstory.

The HERstory

The Birth of Drag: 400 BCE – 1920s

While the term "drag" has existed since around the year of 1388, it was not used to connect to men dressing up as women or women dressing up as men until the year 1870 when the Reynold's newspaper of the United Kingdom used it within this context for the first time. The definition of drag queens as men who dressed up as women most likely originated during the late 1800s, when men wore petticoats that would "drag" on the floor when they were performing as women. While have been performing as women since 400 BCE throughout Ancient Roman, Ancient Grecian, and Shakespearean times, as women were deemed unfit to be performers, it was not until the late 1800s that this practice was called "drag." Around the year 1920 is when the art of drag became associated with homosexuals when it entered the LGBTQIA+ community from the Polari language, which was a secret language that was born to due to fact that homosexuality was being criminalized in England. In 1927, AJ Rosanoff released the "Manual of Psychiatry" in which he finally defined drag as a homosexual male dressed up as a female, or as a social event in which homosexual people show up, and some are dressed up as women.

The Pansy Craze: 1920s – 1930s

During the peak of the Roaring ‘20s, drag queens finally started to enter mainstream. Through cabarets, vaudeville shows, bright nightclubs, and popping bars, the art of drag became incredibly popular until the repeal of prohibition in 1933. However, during the Pansy Craze there was a big divide between types of gay people, including those who were viewed as “fairies” and those who were viewed as “masculine.” Usually, the fairies would dress up as women and dance with the masculine men to avoid getting in trouble with laws against two men dancing together. Usually, a man dressed as a female was deceptive enough and less detectable than two men dancing with each other.

The War on Drag: 1940s – 1970s

At the end of the Pansy Craze, police started to crack down on homosexual acts that they deemed unlawful. Therefore, many homosexual communities were forced underground, including the Jewel Box Revue, which was a troupe made of all drag performers founded in 1939. This group was an incredible force in terms of standing up for gay rights and truly paved the way for the LGBTQIA+ community to feel supported and able to revolt against discrimination. In 1959, Cooper’s Donuts was a small shop in Los Angeles that police officers were known to routinely go to harass cross-dressers and homosexuals. One night in May of 1959, the LGBTQIA+ community had enough and rebelled against these police officers, staging what was known as the first queer riot. This riot paved the way for the Stonewall Riots starting on June 28, 1969, in which a week of riots occurred after police raided the homosexual Stonewall Inn bar, resulting in the first Pride ever. The true heroes of this event were activists like transwoman Marsha P. Johnson, lesbian Storme DeLarverie, and transwoman Sylvia Rivera, who had absolutely no fear rioting against the injustice they were facing. While Stonewall was

not the first queer uprising, it was the first one to be heard all around the world and to genuinely raise concern for how the LGBTQIA+ community was being treated.

The Ballroom: 1980s – 1990s

After the Stonewall Riots, the LGBTQIA+ community felt even more ostracized and pushed aside; therefore, they moved underground and formed what were known as "balls." While the first drag ball dates to 1867 at the Hamilton Lodge in Harlem, they did not become incredibly well known until the 1980s. On top of the police raids, the LGTBQIA+ community was cast away because they were viewed as dirty and contaminated by the AIDS virus. However, if the world was not going to love the community, then the community was going to love each other as shown through the Harlem Ballroom Scene of the 1980s, the 1990 documentary *Paris Is Burning*, and the Wigstock festival! The Harlem Ballroom was primarily frequented by black members of the LGBTQIA+ community who competed for crowns based on their dance moves, their ability to vogue, their fashion, and many other categories. The documentary *Paris is Burning* does a fantastic job documenting just exactly what the ballroom scene is like. At this same time, ballroom started to inspire queens and homosexuals to come back up to the surface a little bit more, resulting in the day long drag festival put on by Lady Bunny in 1984 and the appearances of many famous drag queens in television shows and movies, such as Divine in *Pink Flamingos* and the performers of the *Rocky Horror Picture Show*.

The Reign of RuPaul: 1990s – 2000s

In 1993, the novel drag queen, RuPaul made history when he performed his hit song "Supermodel" at the March on Washington. Following this, RuPaul rose to fame between his many albums, talk show *The RuPaul Show*, and reality competition show *RuPaul's Drag Race*. Today, there have been thirteen seasons of *RuPaul's Drag Race* as well as a plethora of spinoff

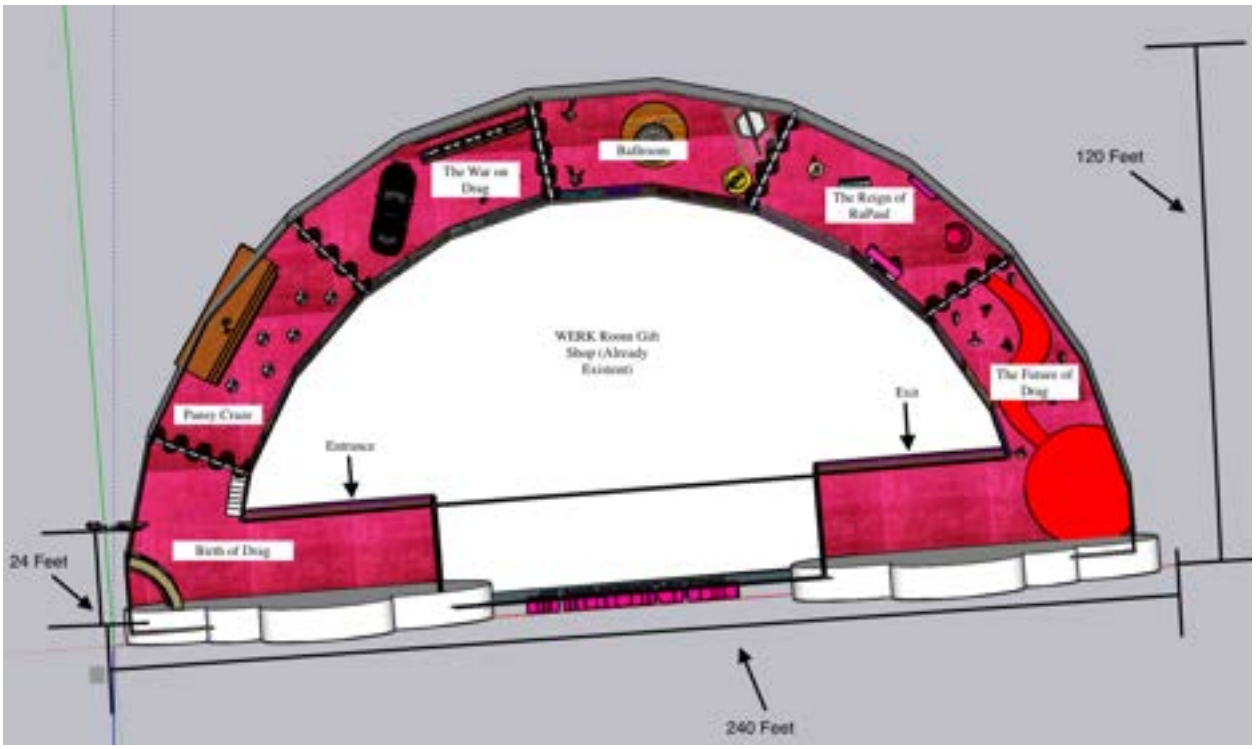
shows! This day in age, RuPaul has made it normal for queer people to be queer and men to dress up as women.

The Future of Drag: TODAY

Throughout history, there has been much debate over what drag is, who can do it, and where it belongs in society. More and more, the answers have become increasingly broad: anyone can do drag, drag is whatever someone wants it to be, and it belongs everywhere. Drag does not just have to be men dressing up as women. Drag kings, or women dressed as men, is also drag! Trans women can dress up as drag kings, and trans men can dress up as drag queens. Someone doing drag can be a pageant queen, a comedy queen, a spooky queen, a club queen, a look queen, or whatever kind of queen or king they want to be! Drag is all about revealing who someone truly is on the inside, and thus the definition of drag has become so much more open to different interpretations.

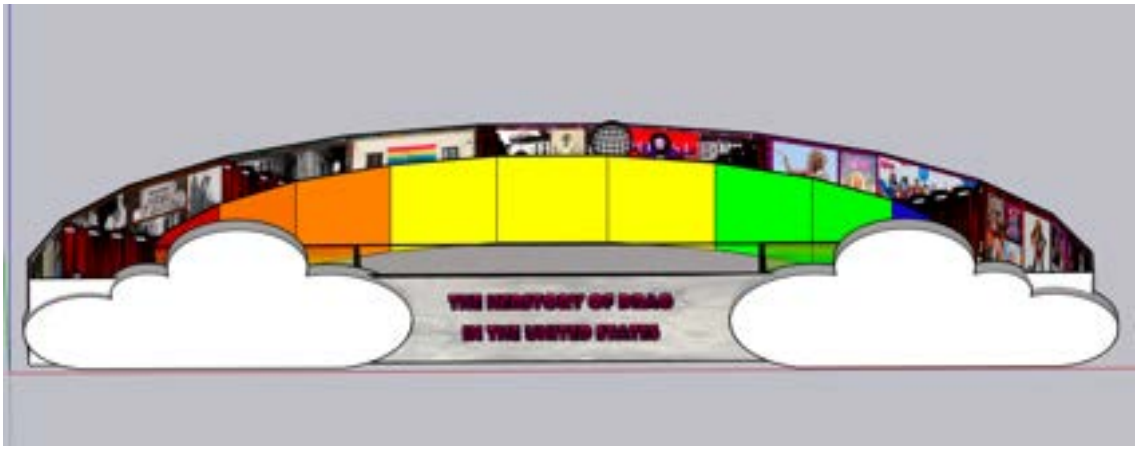
Floorplan

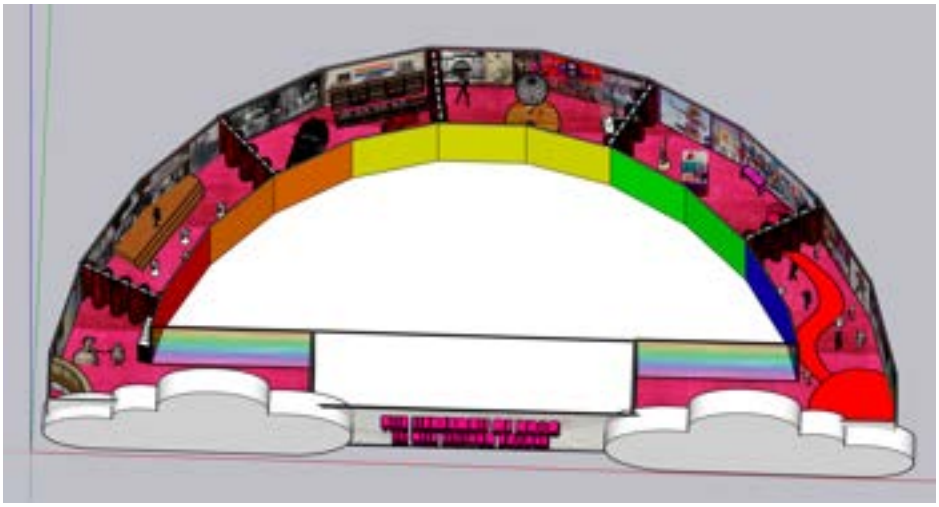
Below is the floorplan of the museum exhibit, including the first room you enter on the left, the Birth of Drag, followed by the Pansy Craze, the War on. Drag, the Ballroom, the Reign of RuPaul, and the Future of Drag. The entrance and exit doors are sliding rainbow doors! The dimensions of the overall floorplan are seen below, and the building itself is 20 feet tall. In the middle of the floorplan is the WERK Room Gift Shop, which is already in place and created at the Flamingo Las Vegas.



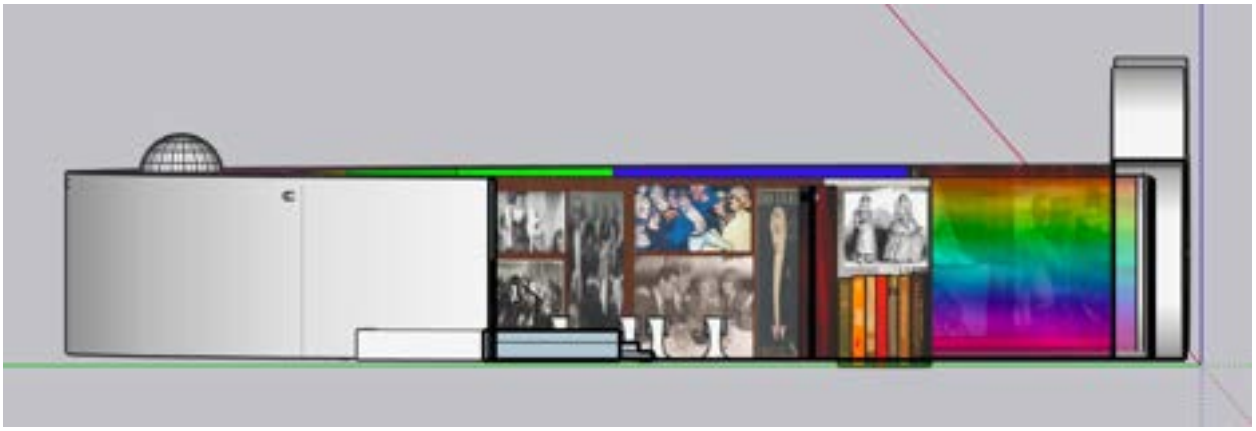
Overall Model

The overall model is in the shape of a rainbow, with clouds on the outside and a cloudy, glass moving door to enter the entire space. Once you enter through the cloudy, glass door, you may enter the rainbow transparent glass door on your left to begin your museum journey, or you may just walk straight in front of you to enter the WERK Room Gift Shop! Ticket attendants will be at the front of the exhibit entrance to make sure you are able to access it. They will then either give you an audio kit that will talk to you as you explore the rooms, or they will assign you a drag queen to give you the tour! All guests attending RuPaul's Drag Race Live at the Flamingo Las Vegas would have already paid for their ticket in their admission for the show, but guests may also purchase exhibit only tickets in the WERK Room.





Following are some quick sections of the inside of the museum exhibit!







The Birth of Drag

As you walk into the Birth of Drag exhibit, you will see the Globe Theatre on the left, as the origins of drag come from the dragging of dresses that men wore when they had to act as women in early theatre. The Reynolds's Newspaper, *Manual of Psychiatry*, and information on the Polari language are hanging up on the wall behind two mannequins of men dressed to play the parts of early Shakespearean roles.



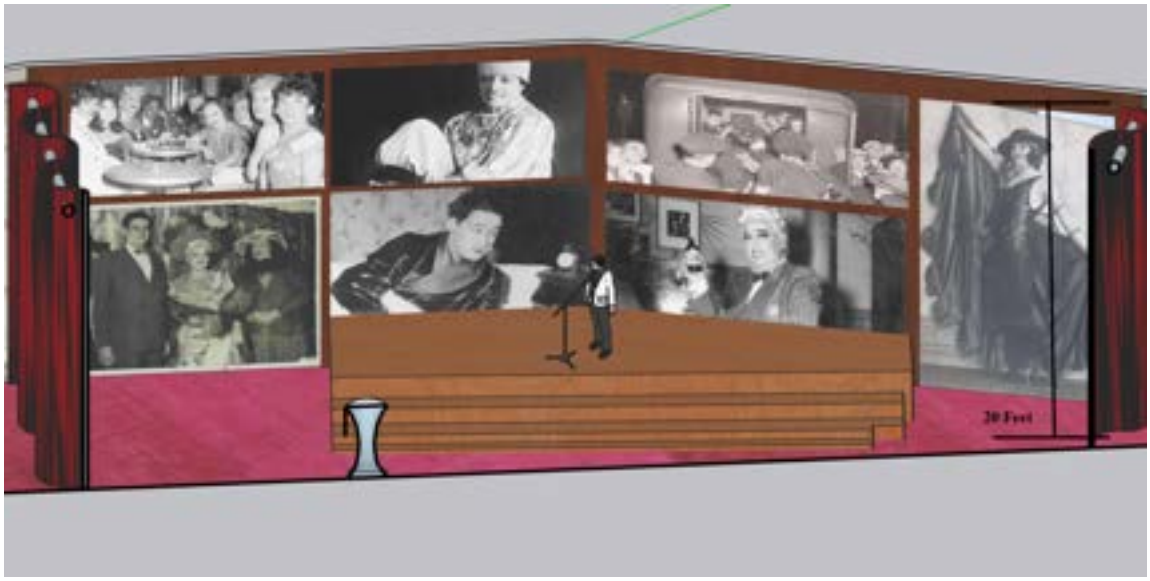


When you start to walk into the next room, to the right you will see some large versions of Shakespeare's plays along with costume sketches.



The Pansy Craze

Continuing into the Pansy Craze exhibit, you will see a stage in the middle of the room with a singer and a microphone. In front of the stage are a whole bunch of white cocktail tables. Surrounding the room, on the walls are pictures of different vaudeville shows during the Pansy Craze as well as many of the different drag performers of the time.






DAS LILA LIED
20 Feet


DAS LILA LIED

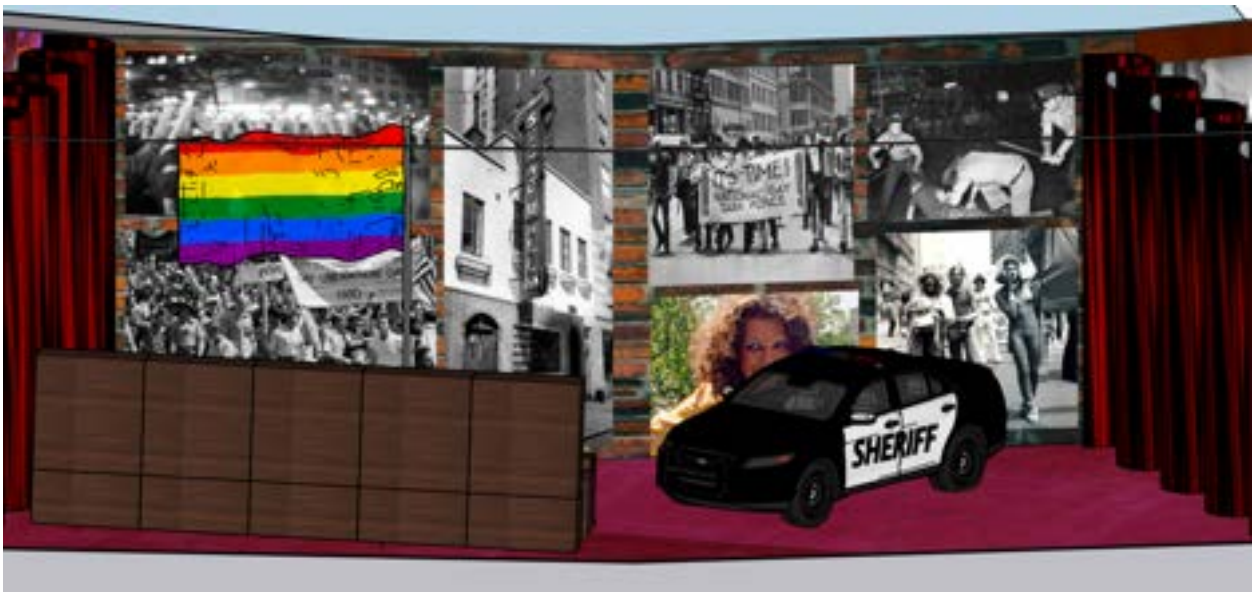
The War on Drag

Walking into the War on Drag exhibit, you will see a police car in the front middle of the room, a rainbow flag on the back right, and a dark brown bar on the back left. Around the room are pictures of the Stonewall Inn Riots as well as pictures of heroes like Marsha P. Johnson, Storme DeLarverie, and Sylvia Rivera.






TIME!
SHERIFF
20 Feet


TIME!
SHERIFF

Ballroom

Next up is the Ballroom exhibit, which has a middle dance floor with vogue hands and a disco ball. In the back of the room, there are trophies, and right when you walk in the room, on the left and the right there are spotlights. Surrounding the room are pictures of Pose, Legendary, the Hamilton Lodge, and William Dorsey Swan. On the right side of the wall are pictures to represent the five elements of vogue, including spins and dips, hands, floor performance, catwalk, and duckwalk.





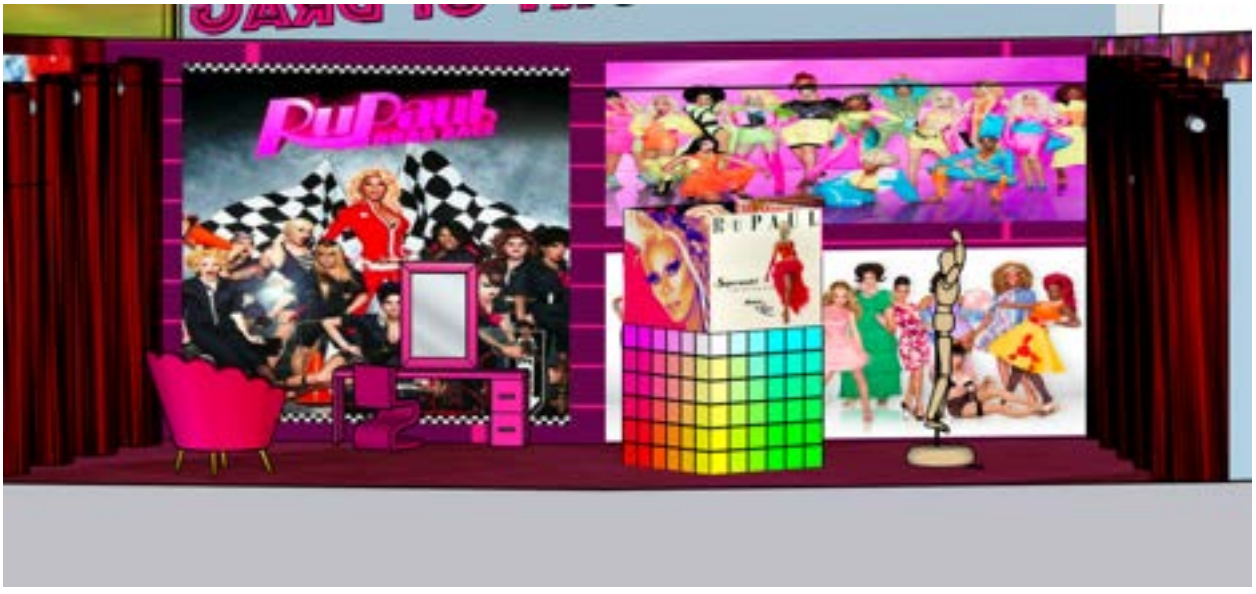




The Reign of RuPaul

Walking into the Reign of RuPaul exhibit, around the room are pictures of some of the casts of RuPaul's Drag Race. The first thing you see in front of you is a mannequin that is doing one of RuPaul's iconic poses. There is a rainbow square in the middle of the room with pictures of RuPaul's albums projected above it. Behind this are some pink mirrors and chairs to give off the energy of being in the WERK Room on RuPaul's Drag Race.






RuPaul
DRAG RACE


RuPaul
DRAG RACE

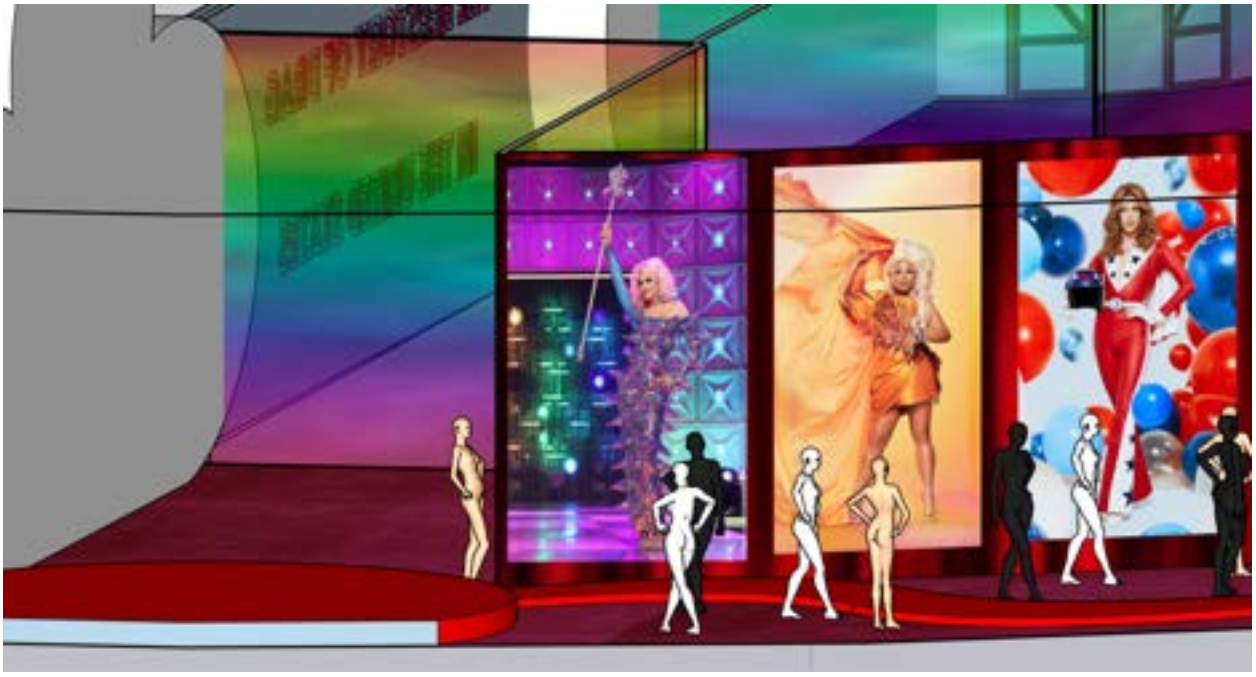
The Future of Drag

Finally, walking into the Future of Drag exhibit, you will be walking on the red carpet surrounded by blank mannequins because YOU are the future of drag, and you get to decide what and who you want to be. Around the building are images of queens who do not fit the traditional drag queen mold, including cisgender straight men, transgender women and men, cisgender women, men dressed as drag kings, drag queens with beards and more! These queens are pushing the boundaries of the definition of drag!









The WERK Room Gift Shop

Below are images of the currently existing WERK Room Gift Shop at the Flamingo, Las Vegas!



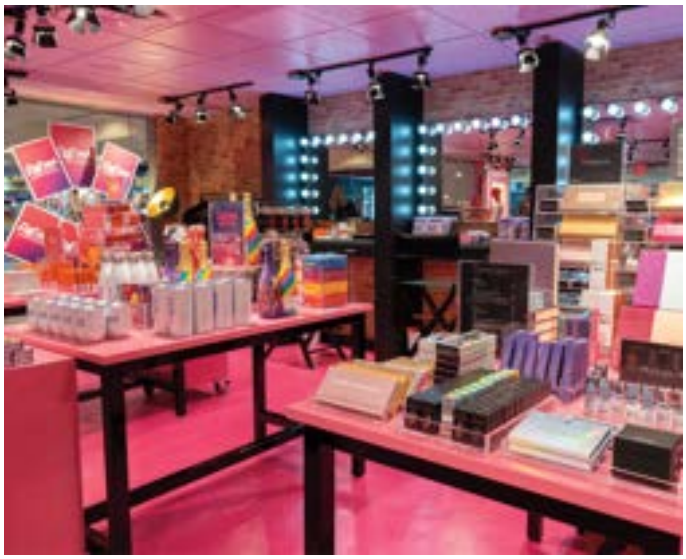
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https://www.caesars.com/flamingo-las-vegas/things-to-do/shopping?web=1&wdLOR=c6BD21BB9-8E9F-B548-BC04-AA3CBA38D70A



https://twitter.com/WorldOfWonder/status/1222903140015464452



https://www.caesars.com/flamingo-las-vegas/shows/rupauls-drag-race-live?web=1&wdLOR=cCE479813-7F54-244F-884A-58E7366C4824

Guest Flow/ Operations/ Capacity

Throughout the entire experience, guests will be able to either listen to the history of the museum through an audio guide, follow a drag queen tour guide who will tell the story, or just walk through the experience completely unguided by anything. The experience is open from 1pm to 1am with 50 people on staff throughout the day. The capacity of the exhibit itself is about 1,200 people, making sure that enough people can walk through without being crowded. The user journey is the following:

1. Enter through the Birth of Drag Exhibit.
2. Continue to the Pansy Craze.
3. Move into the War on Drag.
4. Follow into the Ballroom.
5. Next up is the Reign of RuPaul.
6. Finally, exit after the Future of Drag.

Budget

Given the following expenses and revenues, the estimated yearly profit for this exhibit is about $1,591,389.71.

The HERstory of Drag in the United States Yearly Budget

EXPENSES	
Construction	Budgeted
All Costs Associated with Building	534,602.29 ($1000 Per Square Foot 153,462.29 square feet)
Miscellaneous & Props	$1,000,000.00
Advertisement	Budgeted
Television	$20,000.00
Radio	$15,000.00
Billboards	$30,000.00
Movie Theatres	$10,000.00
Flyers	$6,000.00
Venue Rental	Budgeted
Rent	$600,000.00
Utilities	$250,000.00
Miscellaneous	$100,000.00
Employee Salaries	Budgeted
Yearly Employee Expenses	$2,340,000.00 Employees Per Day, Paid $15 an Hour, Working 12 Hours a Day for 5 Days of 52 Weeks in a Year)
TOTAL EXPENSES	$4,804,602.29

REVENUE	
Ticket Sales	Budgeted
Ticket Revenue from Guests Attending RuPaul's Drag Race Live	$4,056,000 ($20 Additional, Required Fee Added to Each Show Ticket, 780 Attendees Per Show, 5 Shows a Week, 52 Weeks a Year)
Ticket Revenue from Guests Buying an Exhibit Only Ticket	$2,340,000 ($30 Ticket, Average 300 Guests a Day, 5 Days a Week, 52 Weeks a Year)
TOTAL REVENUE	**$6,396,000.00**

TOTALS	
	Budgeted
TOTAL EXPENSES	$4,804,602.29
TOTAL REVENUE	$6,396,000.00
TOTAL PROFIT (LOSS)	$1,591,389.71

Production Schedule

In order to premiere during season 15 of RuPaul's Drag Race, development on this project will begin during July of 2022 and premiere during January of 2023. Below is the production schedule detailing what must be completed every month for a duration of six months.

The HERstory of Drag in the United States Production Schedule

Start Date: July 1, 2022; Open Date: January 1, 2023

Phases	Start of Phase	July	August	September	October	November	December	January
Development								
Develop Museum Concept	6 months							
Preliminary Sketches and Designs	6 months							
Plan Budget	6 months							
Coordination with Flamingo Las Vegas	6 months							
Establish Sponsorship by RuPaul	6 months							
Hire Contractors (Construction and Design)	6 months							
Pre-Production								
Finalize Budget	5 months							
Finalize Story Writing	5 months							
Design the Overall Space	5 months							
Design The Birth of Drag	4 months							
Design The Pansy Craze	4 months							
Design The War on Drag	4 months							
Design The Ballroom	4 months							
Design The Reign of RuPaul	4 months							
Design The Future of Drag	4 months							
Implementation								
Build the Space Around the WERK Room Gift Shop	3 months							
Set Up The Birth of Drag	3 months							
Set Up The Pansy Craze	3 months							
Set Up The War on Drag	2 months							
Set Up The Ballroom	2 months							
Set Up The Reign of RuPaul	2 months							
Set Up The Future of Drag	2 months							
Operation								
Hire Employees and Drag Queens	1 month							
Sell Tickets for the Museum	1 month							
Market the Museum	1 month							
Open Museum	OPENING MONTH							

Conclusion

The HERstory of Drag in the United States Museum is an essential addition needed at the Flamingo Las Vegas Hotel and Casino right outside the venue that hosts the show "RuPaul's Drag Race Live!" In order to educate fans and bring both old and new queens together, this museum would play such an influential role in the LGBTQIA+ community. Easily making a profit and having the sponsorship of RuPaul will make this an incredibly successful exhibit. It will take about six months to create and premiere during the start of a new season of RuPaul's Drag Race! With six different rooms focused on the history of drag, including rooms titled The Birth of Drag, the Pansy Craze, the War on Drag, the Ballroom, the Reign of RuPaul, and the Future of Drag, this is exhibit is sure to be both education and entertaining. So come on down and support this new, revolutionary museum!

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